



NANDI — THE JOURNEY OF AN ABANDONED CALF

A story of separation, fear, survival, compassion and the questions society must answer

THE FIRST SEPARATION — A CALF'S UNIMAGINABLE FEAR

The first wound is not always visible. For a small male calf, being secretly relocated away from his mother for the first time can become a catastrophe he cannot understand. One moment he knows the warmth, smell, voice and protection of his mother; the next, he is placed in an unfamiliar environment among unfamiliar people, roads, animals and noises.

He does not understand ownership, property, economics or human decisions. He understands only one thing: **“Where is my mother?”**

A young calf may be carried, driven, sold, abandoned or otherwise moved away from the place where he was born. When this separation happens without proper care, he may experience fear, confusion, hunger, exposure and repeated attempts to find the familiar herd.

For the calf, it is not another ordinary day. It can be the beginning of a long struggle for food, shelter, safety and belonging.

A hidden relocation can make the situation harder for both mother and calf. The mother may continue searching or calling, while the calf has no reliable way to return. The tragedy becomes almost invisible because it happens away from public attention.

This story is written not to accuse every farmer, owner or citizen. It is written to make us pause before treating a living being as an object that can simply be moved away when inconvenient.

Before a calf becomes “abandoned,” he was somebody’s dependent child. He had a mother. He had a place. He had a biological and emotional bond that mattered to him even if humans did not recognize its value.

The question for society: If our civilization teaches compassion toward all living beings, can we allow convenience, neglect or secrecy to decide the fate of a helpless calf?



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WHEN ABANDONMENT BECOMES A QUESTION OF DHARMA

In the Indian cultural imagination, the cow and calf have long carried deep religious and emotional significance. For many Sanatani Hindus, compassion toward living beings is connected with **daya, ahimsa, dharma and responsibility toward creation**.

Therefore, knowingly abandoning, violently separating, neglecting or treating a helpless calf as disposable should make us examine whether our actions are consistent with the compassionate values we claim to honor.

This is a moral appeal, not a blanket accusation. Circumstances can be complicated: poverty, lack of shelter, illness, family pressure, lack of knowledge and absence of support can all contribute to neglect. But difficulty should lead to better systems of care—not silent abandonment.

A society that worships an ideal but ignores the suffering living being standing in front of it risks turning devotion into symbolism without responsibility.

If we call a calf **NANDI**, let that name remind us that reverence must be accompanied by conduct: food, water, shelter, veterinary attention, protection from cruelty, and responsible care throughout life.

What ordinary citizens can do: report cruelty and abandonment; provide safe water and appropriate food where possible; contact responsible rescuers or veterinary services; discourage people from frightening or chasing calves; support shelters and caregivers; and never participate in dumping a dependent animal somewhere simply because caring for him has become difficult.

What communities can do: create local networks connecting cattle owners, rescuers, veterinarians, municipal bodies and animal-welfare groups so that a problem is addressed before a calf reaches the street.

The aim should not be to shame struggling families. The aim should be to build a culture in which **abandonment is no longer considered an acceptable solution**.

“Dharma is not only what we say we believe. Dharma is also what we choose to do when a helpless being depends upon us.”



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A GOVERNMENT RESPONSIBILITY — FROM NEGLECT TO PROTECTION

Abandoned calves should not be treated as an invisible street-management problem. Government agencies, local bodies and animal-welfare systems should approach abandonment as a combined issue of **animal welfare, public responsibility, prevention and rehabilitation**.

- 1. Create a local emergency response system.** Every district or municipality should have an accessible mechanism for reporting an abandoned or injured calf, with clear responsibility for response, transport, veterinary assessment and temporary shelter.
- 2. Prevent abandonment at the source.** Where owners can no longer care for a calf, there should be a documented surrender or rehoming pathway instead of dumping the animal on roads, fields or unknown locations.
- 3. Strengthen identification and reunification.** When a calf is found alone, authorities and responsible rescuers should make reasonable efforts to identify the owner, herd or mother before permanently relocating the animal.
- 4. Establish safe temporary cattle-care facilities.** Short-term shelters should provide clean water, appropriate nutrition, shade and weather protection, veterinary care and humane handling.
- 5. Protect abandoned animals from secondary dangers.** Roads, aggressive animals, extreme weather, contaminated food, unsafe electrical infrastructure and human cruelty can turn abandonment into a chain of further hazards.
- 6. Accountability with compassion.** Deliberate cruelty or unlawful abandonment should be addressed through applicable animal-welfare laws and procedures. Vulnerable owners should also be offered practical alternatives.
- 7. Support rescuers and caregivers.** People who spend their time rescuing animals often operate with limited money, space and manpower. Government partnerships, transparent support and veterinary assistance can multiply their impact.
- 8. Public education.** Schools, panchayats, municipalities, temples, community groups and agricultural networks can spread simple guidance: do not abandon; do not chase; do not beat; provide water; seek veterinary help; and contact appropriate local authorities or rescue services.

The solution is not simply “catch the calf.” The real solution is prevention → identification → reunification where possible → safe rescue → veterinary care → rehabilitation → responsible long-term placement.



NANDI — THE JOURNEY OF AN ABANDONED CALF

NANDI — THE CALF WHO KEPT CALLING “MAA”

One day I noticed a new abandoned calf on the street. He moved here and there, calling again and again: “**MAA... MAA... MAA...**” Whenever someone approached him, he became frightened and moved away. Even the presence of dogs could make him panic.

Sometimes he tried to approach other cows, perhaps hoping to find food or milk. But when he went near another cow’s shed, the owner would beat or frighten him away to keep him out. The calf did not understand why the door of safety kept closing in front of him.

Then winter came. Cold nights, exposure, hunger, unfamiliar surroundings and the constant need to remain alert added another layer of misery. A young animal who should have been sleeping safely beside his mother was instead learning the geography of fear.

At some point, I also observed reports and suspicions from people about animals being taken away secretly and brutally by groups of wrongdoers. Such allegations should be investigated rather than ignored. No helpless animal should disappear from public view without accountability.

Nandi’s story is larger than one calf. It represents countless abandoned or displaced calves who move through streets without anyone knowing where they came from, where their mothers are, or what happened to them.

A calf calling “MAA” is not making a speech. It is communicating distress in the simplest language available to him.

The street may become his temporary home, but a road is not a mother, a shelter or a family. Survival should not be the only future we offer to a living being who once depended completely on others.



NANDI — THE JOURNEY OF AN ABANDONED CALF

THE NIGHT I MET NANDI — A CONVERSATION BETWEEN TWO LIVES

One night, while feeding stray dogs, I noticed a new calf. I addressed him: “Nandi, what happened? Did your owner abandon you?”

NANDI: “No. My owner was taking me out for a walk for the first time. They loved us deeply. They cared for my mother and me too.”

ME: “Then where is your owner?”

NANDI: “My owner brought me outside for a walk for the very first time. I ran far ahead because I was excited. Somehow my owner and I became separated. Now I am looking for him. Have you seen my owner anywhere?”

ME: “No, I have not seen him yet. Are you sure your owner is also searching for you?”

NANDI: “Of course. Certainly.”

ME: “Okay, calm down. Did you finish your dinner?”

NANDI: “Yes.”

ME: “Then rest here until your owner comes. You look faint.”

NANDI: “Yes. I will sit here and keep waiting for him. You go.”

ME: “Okay. If you need anything, wait here until I return.”

NANDI: “Thank you.”

The next morning, I saw his crying eyes and the heartbreak written across his exhausted face.

NANDI, in a low voice: “I need some milk from my mother. Can you take me home? I think my owner will think I am lost. He may have returned to my mother because he still has to take care of her. My mother will cry when she does not see me in the morning. Please take me home.”

ME: “But I do not know your address.”

NANDI: “I forgot the way in the darkness. How can I meet my mother? I keep roaming everywhere, calling ‘MAA... MAA... MAA...’”



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NANDI'S LAST JOURNEY — AND THE QUESTION HE LEFT BEHIND

Tears suddenly came into my eyes when I saw how overwhelmed he was. I said, “Stop, Nandi. I will do something for you. Until then, have some food and water. I have a surprise for you.”

NANDI: “What is it?”

I comforted him and said, “First finish your food.” After a little food and water, he asked again what the surprise was.

I said, “Let us walk a little farther to the ANS ground. Follow me.” Nandi agreed.

When we reached the field, I showed him many calves grazing inside and outside. Nandi looked surprised: “Who are they?” I said, “They are brothers to you.” He asked, “Brothers? Then why are they here, leaving their mothers alone?”

I encouraged him to meet them and become their friend. He followed my instructions and gradually began to trust me as a friend. I told him I would return that night. He accepted it.

After a week, Nandi said: “I know the truth. I may never meet my mother again. Now they are my friends and the road is my shed. You are like my parent. Then why don’t you take all of us to your home?”

ME: “I am not a rich person. I am as poor as you. I do not have enough space or resources to foster all of you as my children. I have friends too, but everyone is busy in the race of their goals, ambitions and expectations. They may not have enough money or time to contribute.”

NANDI: “Why don’t you tell them? People can have money and power, but sometimes they say they have no time for animals, birds, nature, or abandoned and suffering human beings. I want to dedicate my whole time to serving those who need help. You can contribute money according to your strength.”

ME: “Yes, I have explained everything. But people have different levels of trust, compassion, time and willingness. What can we do except keep trying to awaken compassion in one another?”

I introduced Nandi to fruit and vegetable shops. He did not walk properly at first. When he was hungry or wanted food, he sometimes pushed against me. Slowly, a strange friendship grew around ordinary acts of feeding and care. For about a year, life seemed to be moving forward.

Then, one night of heavy rain, I found Nandi dead inside the ANS field.

I asked people about the possible reason. Some said a snake bite. Others suspected electrocution or an electrical accident near a lamp post. I could not establish the exact cause. What I knew was that Nandi was gone.

I wanted to carry his body myself to a burial place near the bank of the Ganga, but his weight was beyond what I could safely manage alone. I therefore had to call the municipality for disposal. In my heart, I wanted to give him a final farewell according to the rituals I believed he deserved, but nobody supported me and my financial condition did not allow me to fulfill that wish.

LET NANDI'S LIFE BECOME A SOLUTION, NOT ONLY A SAD STORY

Nandi's life leaves us with a question: **What happens when compassion depends entirely on one poor person's strength?** The answer must be a social system in which responsibility is shared.

Solutions: prevent abandonment; create safe surrender and reunification systems; strengthen local rescue and veterinary networks; establish humane temporary shelters; protect calves from traffic, extreme weather, cruelty and electrical hazards; investigate credible reports of animal abuse; support ethical caregivers; and teach children and adults that compassion requires action.

Citizens can contribute time, food, water, transport, veterinary expenses, safe space or financial support. Government can provide infrastructure, coordination and accountability. Rescuers can provide the immediate human connection. Communities can provide long-term support that no single caregiver can provide alone.



Nandi did not ask for luxury. He asked for his mother, safety, food, friendship and a place where he belonged. If society cannot give every animal everything, it can at least stop making abandonment the easiest option.

*Let the memory of Nandi become a mirror: **when a helpless being calls “MAA,” may our first response be compassion, and our next response be responsibility.***

This narrative is based on the storyteller's account and reflections. Individual observations and reported causes of death should be understood as personal testimony unless independently verified.

The Story of Nandi – A Little Calf, A Big Heart

A Story of Love, Loss, Friendship and Unanswered Questions

They may be helpless on the streets, but they feel, they love, they remember.



MAA...
MAA...
MAA...

One day, I noticed a new abandoned-looking calf on the street. He was moving here and there, crying again and again: "MAA... MAA... MAA..."



Whenever someone approached him, he fled. Even dogs frightened him. If he went near other cows hoping to drink milk, the owner of those cows would beat or frighten him away from the cowshed.



In winter, even more misery and challenges were added to his life.



At times, I secretly observed what appeared to be groups of bad actors trying to take advantage of his helplessness. I feared that someone might forcibly take him away.



ME: Nandi, what happened? Did your owner abandon you?

NANDI: No, My owner was taking me outside for a walk for the first time. They love us very deeply. They were taking care of my mother and me too.



ME: Then where is your owner?

NANDI: I have not seen him yet. I also searching for you...?
NANDI: My owner brought me outside for a walk for the very first time. I ran far ahead out of pure excitement. Somewhere along the way, I lost my owner. Now I am looking for him. Have you seen my owner anywhere?



ME: No, I have not seen him yet. Are you sure your owner is also searching for you?

NANDI: Of course. Certainly.

ME: Okay. Just calm down. Did you finish your dinner?

NANDI: Yes.



ME: Then rest here until your owner comes.

NANDI: I feel faint. Yes, I will sit here and keep waiting for him. You go.

ME: Okay. If you need anything, wait here until I return.

NANDI: Thank you.

The next morning, I saw Nandi's crying eyes and the breakdown of his little heart.



NANDI: I need some milk from my mother. Can you take me to my home? I think my owner will think I am lost. He may have returned to my mother because, after all, he has to take care of her. My mother will cry when she does not find me in the morning. Please take me to my home.



ME: But I don't know your address.

NANDI: I forgot the way in the darkness of the night. How can I meet my mother?

And again he wandered arbitrarily, calling: "MAA... MAA..."

Tears suddenly burst into my eyes. Seeing his overwhelming helplessness, I said:

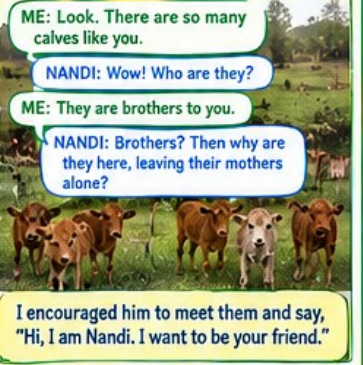


ME: Stop, Nandi. I will do something for you. Until then, have some food and water. I have a surprise for you.

NANDI: What is that, my mom?

I cried, hugged him, pampered him and said, "You first finish your food."

There I showed him many calves grazing inside and outside the field.



ME: Look. There are so many calves like you.

NANDI: Wow! Who are they?

ME: They are brothers to you.

NANDI: Brothers? Then why are they here, leaving their mothers alone?

I encouraged him to meet them and say, "Hi, I am Nandi. I want to be your friend."

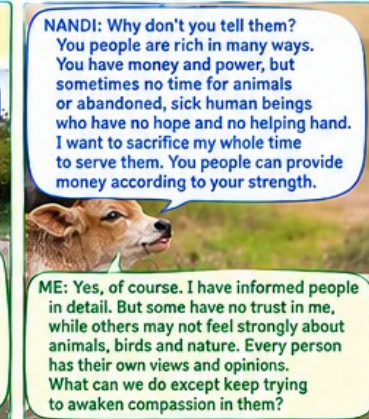
A week later, Nandi seemed to understand a truth that I had been afraid to tell him.



NANDI: I know the truth. I will never meet my mother again. Now they are my friends, and the road is my shed. You are my parent.

Then why don't you take all of us to your home!

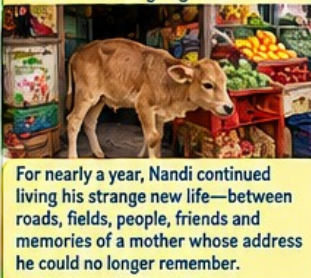
ME: I am not a rich person. I am as poor as you. I do not have enough space or resources to foster all of you as my children. I have friends too, but everyone is busy in the race toward their goals, ambitions and expectations from life. Many feel they do not have enough money or time to contribute.



NANDI: Why don't you tell them? You people are rich in many ways. You have money and power, but sometimes no time for animals or abandoned, sick human beings who have no hope and no helping hand. I want to sacrifice my whole time to serve them. You people can provide money according to your strength.

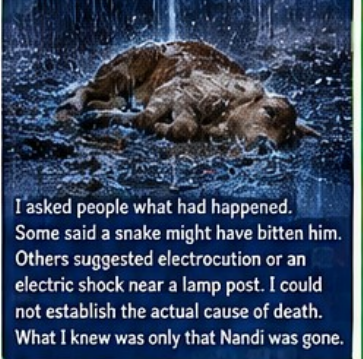
ME: Yes, of course. I have informed people in detail. But some have no trust in me, while others may not feel strongly about animals, birds and nature. Every person has their own views and opinions. What can we do except keep trying to awaken compassion in them?

I introduced Nandi to fruit and vegetable shops. He was not walking properly. When he was hungry or wanted food, he sometimes pushed me with his head. In spite of everything, life seemed to be going well.



For nearly a year, Nandi continued living his strange new life—between roads, fields, people, friends and memories of a mother whose address he could no longer remember.

Then came a night of heavy rain. I found Nandi dead inside ANS Field.

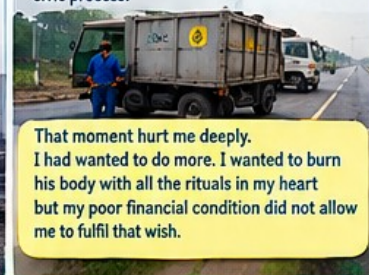


I asked people what had happened. Some said a snake might have bitten him. Others suggested electrocution or an electric shock near a lamp post. I could not establish the actual cause of death. What I knew was only that Nandi was gone.

I wanted to give him a dignified final farewell. I wanted to carry his body myself and perform the rituals I believed he deserved. I wished to take him to a cremation place near the bank of the Ganga. But Nandi was too heavy for me to carry alone.



I called the municipality and his body was disposed of through the available civic process.



That moment hurt me deeply. I had wanted to do more. I wanted to burn his body with all the rituals in my heart but my poor financial condition did not allow me to fulfil that wish.

Sometimes a person can have compassion in abundance but resources in scarcity.



Nandi's life therefore ended with unanswered questions:

- Where was his mother?
- Did his owner continue searching?
- What actually caused his death?
- Could a safe system have reunited him with his family?
- Could someone have protected him from the dangers of the street?



Let us be their voice • "Let us be their hope • Compassion can change lives

